



Into thin air

Like everything else, air is pulled by gravity. Most air molecules are pulled close to the ground, where the air is thick and easy to breathe. Higher up, air is so thin that climbers need oxygen tanks.

From space, the atmosphere looks like a blue haze over the Earth.

Layers of the atmosphere

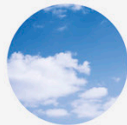
The atmosphere is made up of layers, each with a different name. The bottom layer is the troposphere, where clouds form and planes fly. Above this, the air gets thinner and thinner as the atmosphere merges into space.

Light spectacular

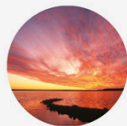
Sunlight can create dazzling effects as it strikes the atmosphere and is scattered by air, water, and dust.



Rainbows form when water droplets reflect sunlight and split it into different colors.



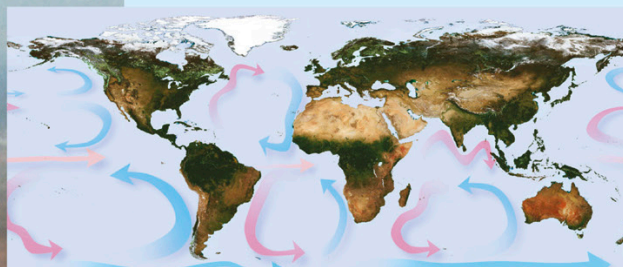
The **sky looks blue** on clear days because air molecules scatter blue light the most.



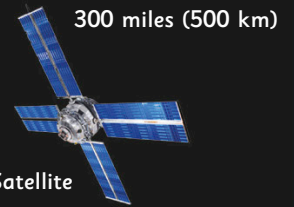
At **sunset**, only the red and orange light of sunlight make it through the atmosphere.

Moving water

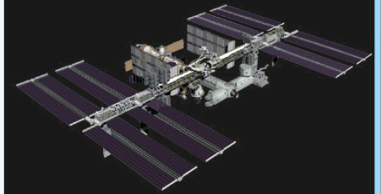
The atmosphere is always swirling around, creating winds. The winds push on the oceans, causing the water to swirl too. These swirling currents carry warmth around the planet.



THERMOSPHERE

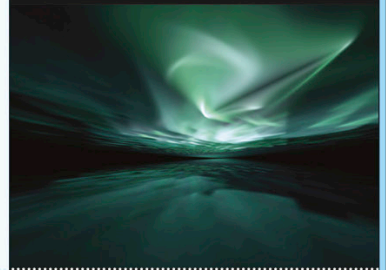


Satellite



International Space Station

Northern lights



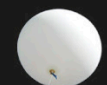
50 miles (85 km)

Shooting stars



MESOSPHERE

30 miles
(50 km)



Weather
balloon

STRATOSPHERE

6 miles (10 km)



TROPOSPHERE

Jumbo jet